CHAPTER II

The Familiar Distance

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“Consider how many conversations in a lifetime never take place. How many questions remain unasked, how many introductions are postponed, how many ordinary opportunities disappear beneath the comforting promise of another day. We are remarkably generous with the time we believe lies ahead of us, seldom considering that some of life’s most enduring regrets may begin not with something we did, but with something we kept meaning to do.”

On the twenty-eighth of March, Utkarsh came to the coaching centre with another restaurant outing to look forward to. A larger group was going this time. Outside, Kolkata was growing warmer; inside, students hurried into the classroom, finishing conversations as they settled into their places. He looked among them for Sanondita.

She had not arrived.

For a while, he kept the possibility of her coming late in mind. A movement at the door interrupted his attention; then the lesson drew it back. By the interval, his friends were already discussing lunch, and he joined them. Deepesh, Abishek, and Saagar would be going, along with Tanisha, Nikita, and several others. He laughed at their remarks and contributed his own. A question about the morning’s work became an argument about something else, and nobody seemed especially concerned with returning to the question.

Sanondita missed the second session too. Utkarsh noticed, although there was nothing to say about it. He had begun to hope that an afternoon together might make speaking to her easier. The

afternoon would have to find other pleasures. There were enough people around him to offer them.

At two o'clock, he was putting away his notebook when Deepesh appeared beside him.

"Come on," he said. "If we spend any more time here, they'll start teaching us again."

"And whose fault would that be?" Utkarsh asked, getting to his feet.

"Certainly not mine. I've been ready since morning."

Outside, Tanisha and Nikita were discussing the journey, while Deepesh offered suggestions whenever the conversation left him room. Saagar waited nearby, pleased that they were finally going somewhere. Abishek listened with the composed patience Utkarsh had come to expect of him.

Their destination was a short local-train journey to the south. The distance was enough to make lunch feel like an excursion. They set off towards the station, with Tanisha and Nikita a little ahead, occasionally looking back to make sure everyone was keeping up. Deepesh divided his attention between walking and making remarks at the others' expense.

"Deepesh, do you ever take anything seriously?" Nikita asked.

"Of course," he replied. "Lunch, for instance. I've been thinking about it since the first class."

"That explains why you weren't listening."

"I was listening. Just not to everything."

Utkarsh laughed. Deepesh went on to defend the intellectual effort required to remain hungry through four hours of coaching. Even Abishek smiled faintly.

At the station, they waited together for the southbound local and boarded when it arrived, finding room wherever the carriage allowed. Utkarsh stood among his friends as the city passed beyond the windows: buildings close to the tracks, crowded platforms, streets visible for a moment before they were gone. He listened to the conversation and joined in when something amused him. With

these people, there was no need to decide in advance what to say. If he was quiet for a while, someone would speak to him; if he laughed, the others already knew why.

At the restaurant, they shifted chairs around a large table until everyone had a place. It was a modest establishment. The menus came out, and Tanisha and Nikita began discussing the order. Deepesh offered his opinion with considerable confidence.

"You seem to know everything about this place," Tanisha observed.

"I know enough."

"Have you been here before?"

"No," Deepesh admitted.

"Then how do you know?"

"Experience," he said solemnly. "I've eaten at other restaurants."

Utkarsh laughed with the others. Saagar studied the menu, looking up now and then to follow the discussion. Abishek spoke when someone addressed him and otherwise let them decide. The older boy's seriousness occasionally made an exchange feel more formal than Utkarsh expected, though he could hardly fault him for being less interested in their nonsense.

Once they had ordered, the talk wandered back towards lessons and examinations, until Deepesh interrupted before lunch could become another coaching session. Then the food arrived, plates were passed, and for a while everyone had a more immediate concern.

Utkarsh looked around the table. Only weeks earlier, he would have known most of these people by where they sat. Now he knew when Deepesh was about to make a joke, when Abishek was likely to remain quiet, how readily Tanisha and Nikita could keep a conversation going. He had wanted to get closer to one person, and in the meantime these others had become people he was glad to know. When someone spoke to him across the table, he answered without thinking of who was missing.

After lunch, nobody was eager to go home. They went elsewhere for dessert, chose their sweets, and continued talking. Deepesh kept making remarks; Tanisha and Nikita kept answering him. Utkarsh smiled, sometimes before the exchange was finished. Sanondita had missed the outing, but he had not spent it merely waiting for her.

April brought heavier heat and the approaching end of his sixth semester. His college examinations were still some weeks away, yet unfinished portions of the syllabus had begun to trouble him. There were subjects to revise and decisions to make about which work deserved the next few hours. Coaching continued at its usual pace, indifferent to the other examinations for which its students had to prepare.

On the mornings he attended, Deepesh sometimes greeted him as though he had returned from a prolonged disappearance.

"Look who's here. I thought you'd graduated and forgotten us."

"I haven't graduated yet."

"Then why are you practising disappearing?"

"College examinations."

"Ah," Deepesh said gravely. "A perfectly respectable excuse. I was beginning to think you'd found a better coaching centre."

"If I had, would I be here?"

Deepesh considered this. "Fair point. Their admission standards must be terrible."

Utkarsh laughed. The joke made returning easy, even when the choice to come had not been. College required him to finish what he had already begun. Coaching belonged to a future that was less certain and would demand more patience. Some mornings, staying home to revise was plainly sensible. On others, the thought of missing the classroom made that sensible decision harder to keep.

Over the following days, he noticed Sanondita spending less time with the group. At first, she sat with them on one morning and elsewhere on another. Gradually, a place in the first row of the left-hand column became customary. A young woman he came to

know as Diya sat beside her. Sanondita occupied the seat nearest the wall.

Utkarsh watched the new arrangement become familiar from farther back in the room. He had spent weeks getting to know her friends, hoping it might become easier to know her too. Now he belonged among them, and she was sitting elsewhere.

Well, that worked out beautifully.

The thought amused him, though the disappointment remained. She had no reason to choose a seat according to an intention he had never expressed. He could see how absurd it was to feel thwarted by someone who knew nothing of his plan. Yet he had grown comfortable with the idea that proximity would eventually do the work of an introduction. Seeing her at the front made him recognise how little that comfort had accomplished.

From his place towards the back, he began noticing details he could have recalled even on a morning when she was absent. She usually carried a purse over her shoulder rather than a backpack like his. Loose-fitting jeans, a T-shirt, glasses with delicately pink frames. Her straight hair was often gathered into a loose bun, held by a large claw clip. When she adjusted it, he sometimes caught sight of the small earrings along her ear.

He liked watching her attend to the lesson. While conversations rose and faded nearby, she bent over her notebook and continued writing. The seriousness of that attention seemed to belong to her as readily as the glasses or the way she wore her hair. She appeared at ease with herself, although he understood that appearances could tell him only so much.

Still, he had begun to look forward to seeing her occupied with things that had nothing to do with him. A morning could feel different because she was there. He found this difficult to admit, even privately: she had become part of his expectations without knowing she had a place in them.

Diya was not always present. On those mornings, another student might take the place beside Sanondita, settling into a chair

or onto one of the two-person benches when the room was arranged that way. Utkarsh sometimes noticed before he had properly opened his own notebook.

Sanondita might exchange a few words with the person beside her and smile briefly, or remain quiet and turn her attention to the lesson. With Diya, the familiarity was easier to see. They spoke seriously at times; at others, a small smile passed between them. Utkarsh had never heard Sanondita laugh loudly as Deepesh did. The happiness he witnessed was quieter, sometimes over before he had fully registered it.

It was when another boy sat beside her that he became most uncomfortable with his own attention.

The boy could walk into the room, see an empty place, and sit down. Utkarsh watched the ordinary ease of it. He had rehearsed a dozen ways of beginning a conversation, yet someone else required no more than a vacant seat. Then Sanondita would say something, or smile, and he would discover that the irritation had already arrived.

Why should it bother me?

He knew she was free to speak to anyone. His feeling gave him no claim on the place beside her. Knowing that did not spare him the sting of seeing someone occupy it, and the sting embarrassed him because he could not blame either of them for it.

Once or twice, he questioned whether the boy was paying attention to the lesson. A notebook lay open; a pen moved occasionally. Was he actually listening? The suspicion pleased him for scarcely a moment before he recognised how convenient it was. Perhaps the boy was studying. Perhaps Utkarsh had supplied an intention because he knew what his own would have been.

He disliked being unfair to someone who might have done nothing beyond arriving for class. Yet he could not simply decide to stop feeling what he felt. When Sanondita returned to her notes, the restlessness stayed with him. She had no idea that anything had happened.

What have I got to lose?

There was no promise, no affection offered, scarcely the beginning of an acquaintance. What unsettled him was the ease with which someone else could become familiar to her while he continued to imagine doing so. He could recover a missed lesson. He could not recover a conversation in which he had never taken part.

He might have chosen that seat himself on another morning. Whenever he imagined walking towards it, however, he also imagined her looking up and wondering why he was there.

What if she doesn't want me there?

He was afraid of making her uncomfortable. He was afraid of being embarrassed. The two concerns were so closely entangled that he could not always distinguish courtesy from an excuse to remain where he felt safe. From a distance, he could continue looking forward to her presence without discovering whether she wanted his.

So he stayed among the people he knew, with his notes before him and another opportunity somewhere ahead. The following class would be easier, perhaps. He had made that promise often enough that it no longer required much thought.

Tanisha and Nikita had already guessed his interest, and occasionally one of them returned to it when the lessons were over.

"So, Utkarsh," Tanisha began one afternoon, "how is everything going?"

"Quite well, thank you."

"Everything?"

He looked at her. "Is there a particular subject you're interested in?"

Nikita smiled. "I think you know which subject."

"Arithmetic?"

"Sanondita," Tanisha replied.

"Ah. That subject."

“And?” Nikita asked.

“And what?”

“Have you spoken to her again?”

Utkarsh shook his head.

Tanisha stared at him for a moment. “You’re still at the same place?”

“Not exactly,” he said. “I’ve changed my seat.”

Nikita burst into laughter. Tanisha looked exaggeratedly disappointed.

“Wonderful,” she said. “At this rate, you’ll have explored the entire classroom before introducing yourself.”

“I’m making progress geographically.”

“Romantically, you’re going backwards.”

“That’s a rather harsh assessment.”

“It’s a generous one,” Nikita replied.

He laughed with them. They teased without making his interest into a serious matter, and he was grateful. Neither took it upon herself to arrange an introduction. They had their own concerns, and his reluctance did not become their responsibility.

Afterwards, their question stayed with him.

Have you spoken to her again?

He could still remember the answer he had given about Arithmetic on that first morning. He had spoken before considering how it would sound. Now even a greeting seemed to require preparation. He tried imagining a question about the lesson, some remark another classmate could make without hesitation. The words became awkward only when he imagined saying them to her. He wanted the exchange to be ordinary, yet cared too much about its reception to let it feel that way.

By the middle of May, he was opening one textbook while worrying about another. The remaining portions of his sixth-semester syllabus looked more threatening than they had in

April. Some mornings, he stayed home to revise instead of attending coaching. It was usually the right decision.

Then he would begin wondering what he had missed.

The lessons could be recovered through notes, explanations, and an appeal to a classmate. What troubled him was everything too small for anyone to report. Had Sanondita come? Had Diya been there? Had a conversation taken place, a smile passed, an ordinary moment ended before he could see it?

He had no useful question to ask his friends. Whatever had happened in her day belonged to her. Yet he found himself wishing to know, even while the work he had stayed home to do waited before him.

One afternoon, he read the same passage three times without remembering it. At last, he shut the book and looked at the cover.

Wonderful. Six semesters of college, and apparently I've forgotten how to read.

He laughed at himself, opened it again, and forced his attention back to the page. There were papers to pass. Sanondita would not be sitting them for him. The thought was practical enough to help, and he worked on.

On one of the few mornings he managed to attend coaching, Deepesh was examining a page of notes as though it contained evidence of a serious crime.

"Whose handwriting is this?" he demanded as Utkarsh approached.

"Yours?"

"Unfortunately. I was hoping someone had exchanged my notebook."

Utkarsh leaned over the page.

"What does that say?"

"That's precisely what I'm trying to establish."

Tanisha glanced up from nearby.

"Perhaps you should have listened when sir was explaining it."

“I did listen,” Deepesh protested. “My hand simply disagreed with what my ears heard.”

Nikita laughed. Utkarsh, who had arrived thinking about the work waiting at home, laughed too. He settled into an empty chair and joined the discussion of whether Deepesh’s notes were of any use to humanity.

For several minutes, he forgot his unfinished revision and the person whose presence he had checked on entering. He was simply there, enjoying himself. When the teacher arrived and he opened his notebook, he recognised how much he had missed this company. He had become accustomed to being greeted, drawn into a joke, expected to answer. In the days he stayed away, those small forms of welcome had been missing too.

June brought the examinations and a heat that made journeys through Kolkata feel longer than they were. For several days, Utkarsh’s life narrowed to question papers, revision, crowded travel, and the relief of remembering an answer when he needed it. Coaching had to wait.

Before one paper, he reached college early and found other students revising outside. Someone explained a topic with such confidence that he began to doubt his preparation, until another student pointed out that the explanation belonged to a different subject. The argument that followed was more entertaining than the notes in his hand. He smiled, put them away, and waited to go in.

During the examination, his attention remained where it was needed. Later, travelling home with another paper behind him, he looked out at the city and thought of the classroom at coaching. At college, an ending he had anticipated for years was approaching. Elsewhere in the same city, mornings were passing in a room to which he wanted to return. He wondered what he would find when he did, and whether he would finally manage to begin the conversation he had kept postponing.

After the examinations, the coaching centre seemed scarcely altered. The corridor carried the same footsteps and overlapping voices. Someone was still arguing that a question with one supposedly correct answer had none.

Deepesh greeted him with exaggerated concern.

“We were beginning to think you’d graduated from society altogether.”

“Only from college,” Utkarsh replied. “And even that’s subject to the results.”

“A sensible precaution. Never celebrate until the university has agreed with you.”

Utkarsh laughed and went into the classroom. He took an empty seat and searched his bag for a pen. When he glanced towards the first row, he saw Sanondita beside Diya.

Her pink-framed glasses were familiar at once. She was listening to Diya, and then she smiled. It lasted only a moment. Before she turned back to her notebook, Utkarsh found himself smiling too.

He looked down, embarrassed by the ease with which his face had answered an expression meant for someone else.

For weeks, he had wondered what his absence might have cost him. Now she was there, and the simple pleasure of seeing her made those private calculations feel foolish. Her days had continued. She had attended to lessons, spoken to Diya, gone home. He knew only the little of it that he could witness from his seat.

The lesson began. Pages turned around him, and he opened his own notebook. He was happy to be back. For once, he let the feeling remain without questioning it.

By the end of June, what unsettled him was how important these brief glimpses had become while Sanondita herself remained almost a stranger. He remembered the way she adjusted her glasses, the quiet smiles she shared with Diya, how she looked when she approached her place in the first row. He knew her name.

He did not know what frightened her, what made her truly happy, or how she spoke among people who knew her well. He could recognise her across the room and still have no idea how her day had been. The familiarity was real within his own life. He could not assume that it existed in hers.

One afternoon, when the lesson ended, he watched her rise, gather her belongings, and leave with Diya. Students followed them into the corridor. Utkarsh remained seated for a moment, listening to the classroom empty.

She had done what she did every day. There had been no reason to stop her, no conversation to finish. Yet as the sounds receded, he thought of a morning when the seat nearest the wall might remain empty. He could wait through the first session, then the second. The next day, he could look again.

How would he know when to stop expecting her?

She might leave the coaching centre without any reason to tell him. There would be no farewell between them. He would not know that their last ordinary afternoon had been the last until there were no more of them.

He had given so much thought to whether she would welcome a conversation that he had scarcely considered what it would feel like never to have one. Now the possibility hurt. He could remember months of her presence, yet there was so little she could remember of his.

At last, he picked up his bag and stood. Beyond the coaching centre, Kolkata was full of people passing one another, each on the way to somewhere else. Somewhere among them was Sanondita, going on with a day whose smallest details he would have liked to know.

She did not yet know his name.

For the first time, Utkarsh was afraid that she never would.